SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #30 · SIN

“Some sins can’t be forgiven until I confess them to a priest.”

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Where it often comes from

Church teaching that tied forgiveness of serious sins to confession with a priest. Fear of dying before you could get to confession. Shame that keeps you from going to confession, leaving you feeling stuck and unforgiven. Not knowing how to confess directly to God. Some traditions value confession to a priest as a helpful practice; the lie is that God *cannot* forgive you when you come to Him directly in Christ.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture shows people confessing directly to God and being forgiven. David said, “I will confess my transgressions to the LORD,” and God forgave the guilt of his sin. The tax collector simply prayed, “God, have mercy on me, a sinner,” and Jesus said he went home justified. Through Christ, you can approach God’s throne of grace yourself. Confessing to other believers is also encouraged in Scripture and can bring healing, but it is Christ who forgives.

> *“Then I acknowledged my sin to You and did not hide my iniquity. I said, ‘I will confess my transgressions to the LORD,’ and You forgave the guilt of my sin”* **(Psalm 32:5)**.

Also see

> “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” **(1 John 1:9)**.

> “But the tax collector stood at a distance, unwilling even to lift up his eyes to heaven. Instead, he beat his breast and said, ‘God, have mercy on me, a sinner!’ I tell you, this man, rather than the Pharisee, went home justified. For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted” **(Luke 18:13–14)**.

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” **(Hebrews 4:16)**.

> “Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail” **(James 5:16)**.

Common self-statements

- God won’t forgive me until I go to confession.
- This sin is too serious for just praying.
- If I die before confession, I’m lost.
- I’m too ashamed to confess, so I’m stuck.
- My prayers alone don’t count.
- Someone else has to declare me forgiven.

Common logical errors

- **Overgeneralization:** Turning a church practice into a limit on God’s power to forgive.
- **Catastrophizing:** Imagining the worst if you cannot reach a priest in time.

- **Discounting Scripture:** Overlooking examples of people confessing directly to God.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding "I don't feel forgiven, so I'm not."

Challenging questions

- What happened when David confessed directly to the LORD?
- Did the tax collector need a priest to go home justified?
- What does 1 John 1:9 promise when I confess?
- Who is my great high priest?
- Can I value confession with others and still know that God forgives me directly?
- Is fear keeping me from God, rather than bringing me to Him?
- What would change if I confessed to God right now?

Truth summary

> I can confess my sins directly to God, and He is faithful and just to forgive me. Jesus is my great high priest, and through Him I can come to God's throne of grace. Confessing to other believers can bring healing, and I may choose to do that, but God's forgiveness is not out of my reach. When I confess to Him, He forgives.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Confession
- Forgiveness
- Prayer, How to
- Repent
- Christ, Mission of

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Prayer
- Sin

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Some sins can't be forgiven until I confess them to a priest"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Some sins can't be forgiven until I confess them to a priest." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What happened when David confessed to the LORD?
- ☐ Did the tax collector need a priest?
- ☐ What does 1 John 1:9 promise me?
- ☐ Who is my great high priest?
- ☐ Is fear keeping me from God?
- ☐ What would change if I confessed to God now?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can confess my sins directly to God.
- ☐ When I confess, God is faithful to forgive.
- ☐ Jesus is my great high priest.
- ☐ God's forgiveness is not out of my reach.
- ☐ Confessing to others can help me heal.
- ☐ I can approach God's throne of grace with confidence.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 32:5**
  "Then I acknowledged my sin to You and did not hide my iniquity. I said, 'I will confess my transgressions to the LORD,' and You forgave the guilt of my sin."
- [ ] **1 John 1:9**
  "If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."
- [ ] **Luke 18:13–14**
  "But the tax collector stood at a distance, unwilling even to lift up his eyes to heaven. Instead, he beat his breast and said, 'God, have mercy on me, a sinner!' I tell you, this man, rather than the Pharisee, went home justified. For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted."
- [ ] **Hebrews 4:16**
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."
- [ ] **James 5:16**
  "Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Confession journal:** Each night, write a short, honest confession to God, then write: "You forgave the guilt of my sin."
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, 1 John 1:9 becomes: "If **Sarah** confesses **her** sins, He is faithful and just to forgive **her** sins and to cleanse **her** from all unrighteousness."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Confession" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write a simple prayer of confession to God** about something weighing on you, read it aloud, and then thank Him for His forgiveness.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 32 and Psalm 51,** and notice how David speaks directly to God.
- ☐ **Consider confessing one struggle to a trusted believer** for prayer and support, as James 5:16 encourages.
- ☐ **If your church has a practice of confession,** talk with your pastor or priest about what it means and what it does not mean.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Some sins can't be forgiven until I confess them to a priest": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One thing I confessed to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Some sins can't be forgiven until I confess them to a priest.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that through Jesus I can come to You directly. Help me reject the lie that some sins cannot be forgiven until I confess them to a priest. I confess my sins to You now, trusting Your promise to forgive and cleanse me. Thank You for the believers who pray with me, and for Christ, my great high priest. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.